

Anarchy Is Love



Love Is Anarchist

How Capitalism Gets In The Way Of Love And Anarchism Frees It

Many A True Word Spoken In Jest

This article started as a joke. In a conversation with a friend I was making light of how a few right-wing commentators claim there is only freedom under capitalism, and I responded saying that idea was as absurd as believing that love can only exist under Anarchism. However, that has got me thinking ever since about where love might fit best within the spectrum of political ideologies.



When most people think about love, however, ideology doesn't usually come into it. Even if they look for those who share the same outlook as them, there are other factors apart from this that are part of the initial spark, even if shared ideals may help sustain a relationship over time.

But ideologies do impact relationships, especially if those with the ideals have power to affect others. Ideological laws which may determine what kinds of adult relationships are favoured or even criminalised have long affected what kinds of love are seen as acceptable (such as restrictions on homosexuality in the past). While love can emerge in such harsh circumstances and even grow despite

adversity, these constraints often place an immense strain on relationships.

But there are more subtle ways in which politics impacts our social lives, such as meeting and associating with others being effected by government monetary policies. As the cost of going out can determine where and if people meet up, what they do, and how long they can afford to spend when they get there.

Love Is Anti-Capitalist

This leaves me wondering, 'Is it possible that perhaps no other political and economic system is worse for love than capitalism?' Under Capitalism everything that can be will be bought and sold and valued by its ability to produce a profit. Could this apply to romance too?



Sophia & Leo Tolstoy (War & Peace) - together 48 years

As the Beatles song goes 'Money can't buy me love'. Love can do many things, but it cannot be extracted from someone like a mineral from a mine, nor can it be stolen by a thief like a necklace from a jewellery box. Yet capitalism attempts to commodify every aspect of human connection. Under this system, you can buy titillation, attention, and even simulations of passion - although these are mere substitutes for consensual love.¹

1 While there's no judgment for those who provide or respectfully use such services - purchasing attention is not the same as consensual shared love.

We see this commodification everywhere: dating apps turning romance into a marketplace, subscription services promising connection through a screen, even the basic infrastructure of love locked behind economic barriers.

There are too many paywalls blocking authentic connection: the cost of 'third places' where people might meet naturally, the crushing weight of rent and mortgages that keep people trapped in bad situations or unable to build lives together, even the need to maintain employment and health insurance to ensure loved ones can receive medical care. Each of these represents another way capitalism places a price tag on social interactions and makes unfettered love more difficult to find and maintain.

Love Is Free

In contrast with this, at its heart, love is free, it is not a property relationship. While we might poetically say 'I'm yours' or 'I belong to you', no one has the right to own another person. Conservatives try to force people into marriage and to stay even in bad marriages, as if trapping sunbeams in a box will help preserve them, even when the light is long gone. Even liberals focus on the legality of marriage, but the state's involvement does not define the strength of relationships.



*Oscar Wilde (Dorian Gray) & Alfred Douglas
- together 7 years - imprisoned for their love*

But what makes such voluntary association truly possible? At its core, it requires sincere consent - not merely the absence of force, but the presence of real choice and autonomy. This creates a virtuous cycle: Freedom to consent enables real choice, choice creates autonomy, and autonomy reinforces freedom.²

In contrast, capitalism and hierarchy corrupt consent through coercion and power imbalances. A partner dependent on shared housing might 'agree' to situations they would otherwise reject.

Economic pressures, gender roles, and societal expectations create invisible constraints that limit self-determination. Even seemingly personal decisions in such circumstances become shaped by systemic pressures. Whereas, the dynamics of true consent require:

- Personal autonomy.
- Real alternatives and choices.
- Freedom from social coercion.
- Absence of exploitable power imbalances.
- Ability to leave without facing destitution.
- Protection from social isolation.

Just as workers under capitalism must 'consent' to exploitation to survive, people in hierarchical relationships often 'consent' to situations they would otherwise reject if given real freedom.³ This demonstrates how personal liberation is inseparable from broader social liberation, and points to why love itself naturally aligns with Anarchism.

Love Is Anarchism

When we recognise that authentic love requires freedom from coercion, we see how our fundamental interconnection leads us to a crucial truth: Though our initial feelings may catch us unexpectedly, the act of sharing and nurturing love is always a voluntary choice. This element of free collaboration, of choosing to build something meaningful together without pressure to do so, aligns perfectly with Anarchist principles of mutual aid and voluntary cooperation.

2 This concept is a theme I hope to return to in a future article.

3 I'm not judging personal consensual relationship dynamics which are freely entered into here, but addressing systemic power imbalances and economic coercion.

Love might begin with attraction, but it deepens through shared understanding and mutual care. This is why ideologies that reject compassion and cooperation as weakness⁴, inevitably lead to isolation. While those who wall themselves off from personal ties - whether through fear, conditioning, or ideological belief - miss love's transformative potential.



Lucía Saornil & Mercè Guillén (Spanish Civil War) - 34 years

The materially privileged often avoid truly understanding others' situations because it would demand confronting systemic injustice. Similarly, those who reject their need for others often do so from learned independence, building walls of false self-sufficiency that prevent heartfelt connection. Both responses serve capitalism's need to keep us separated and hierarchical.

While individual kindness and understanding cannot alone overthrow systemic oppression, they create spaces where love can flourish despite those systems. When we understand our shared social bonds and act with genuine care for others' wellbeing, we naturally resist hierarchy and move toward communal care and collective liberation.

Of course romantic love is just one form of love's transformative power. In all its forms - from friendship to community solidarity - love embodies anarchist principles: willingly given, based on mutual care, with the freedom to change or end relationships that no longer serve both parties. This broader understanding of love grows from our capacity for compassion and recognition of shared humanity.

4 See Incel philosophy or Randian 'Objectivism' for examples of this.

These aren't mere personal virtues, but essential aspects of how we form bonds with each other, even within oppressive systems.

True compassion isn't about pity or superiority. It means understanding that everyone's needs matter, that we find fulfilment through mutual understanding and support. It shows itself in practical ways - in sharing what we have, in standing together against hardship, in recognising that individual comfort means little while others suffer. When we see someone without housing while others hoard empty properties, compassion moves us toward action and sharing.

This is not about self-denial or insecurity, but honestly recognising that none of us exists in isolation. We need each other, we strengthen each other, we survive through cooperation. This understanding naturally conflicts with capitalism's demands for competitive individualism - how can we accept hoarding resources while others go without? How can we claim the right to rule over others when we understand our collective reliance on one another?

Love Beyond Capitalism

Imagine love unfettered by economic pressure and hierarchy. In a world built on community solidarity rather than exploitation, relationships could develop their full potential because:

- Partners maintain individual autonomy while choosing to cooperate.
- Material needs don't create dependency or force compromises.
- Community support provides realistic alternatives.
- Power imbalances can't be exploited for control.
- Each person remains free to grow, change, and if needed, separate.

In this way, love doesn't just exist despite capitalism - it actively points the way forward. Every time people choose to support each other's freedom, to build relationships based on shared support rather than dependency, they create tiny pockets of liberation. These

relationships show us glimpses of what's possible when we embrace authentic consent as the foundation for human intimacy. Every truly consensual relationship becomes a small demonstration of ignoring or rejecting hierarchy - people choosing to build something together without compulsion, supporting each other's autonomy while maintaining their own. These moments of natural connection and mutual support aren't just personal choices - they're revolutionary acts that demonstrate another world is possible.



Emma Goldman & Alexander Berkman (Activists) - together 47 years

While we need each other, we must choose to act on that need freely. Though our initial feelings may catch us unexpectedly, the act of sharing and nurturing love is always a voluntary choice.

Anarchism Is Love

When people tell me Anarchy is impractical, impossible and will never win, I respond by telling them it already does - often and in the most important ways. Love transcends capitalism's constraints. Love wins, keeps winning despite the odds. It wins every time people connect across artificial barriers of culture, class, and caste. It persists despite attempts to monetise it, to restrict it, to control it. Every time people share resources without expecting return, support each other through hardship, or choose cooperation over competition,

they're practicing Anarchism. Love shows us that human nature isn't inherently competitive or hierarchical - like water finding its level, humans naturally flow toward patterns of reciprocal care and freely chosen kinship when barriers are removed.⁵



Sophia & Peter Kropotkin (Mutual Aid) - together 43 years

Anarchism is realised when agreements are made willingly, when love and desire are not turned into commodities for sale, when the state isn't involved or contracted with.⁶ In the end, true Anarchism might simply be the universal application of love's principles: freely chosen association, communal care, the rejection of hierarchy and coercion, mutual growth without constraints, and the freedom to evolve together.

How do we build relationships that prefigure the world we want to see? How do we practice love as resistance? These questions of removing hierarchy and capitalism from our relationships deserve their own thorough examination, which I hope to address in a future article. For now, recognising love's inherently Anarchist nature reminds us that liberation is not just possible - it's already happening in every act of true love and solidarity.

⁵ At least where insecurity due to artificial scarcity are removed.

⁶ Though people may legally marry for practical protections.

Love, Consent, and Liberation

Why Healthy Relationships Are Better With Anarchy

‘I love you.’

Three words that should represent freedom, joy, and genuine connection. It is the subject of songs, the theme of films, and a major genre of literature. It crosses several fields of scientific study and sits at the heart of many religions and philosophies. ‘I love you’ is a powerful sentence whether that love is shared freely between partners, good friends, or close family. For many people, those words are said freely and represent real care and kindness, comfort and affection. They come with acceptance and without unreasonable conditions.

Yet how often do these same words mask control? How many relationships claiming love actually lack consent? And if we can recognise the warning signs of an abusive romantic relationship, why do we struggle to see the same patterns in our workplaces and in our political and economic systems?



Let's explore what genuine love requires, and why the same principles that make personal relationships healthy apply equally to political ones.

The Foundation: What Makes Love Real?

Picture two relationships:

Relationship A: 'I love you, so I've decided what's best for you. I'll manage your money because you're not good with finances. I need to know where you are at all times – it's for your own safety. You need to cut off from friends who are 'bad influences.' Everything I do is because I love you and want to protect you.'

Relationship B: 'I love you, which means I trust you to make your own decisions. We'll figure out finances together, respecting each other's autonomy. I'm happy you maintain your friendships and pursue your interests. We'll support each other's growth, even when we disagree about the path.'

Most of us immediately recognise Relationship A as abusive, regardless of how many times 'love' gets mentioned. We understand instinctively that love without consent, without genuine choice, without autonomy, isn't love at all. It's control wearing love's mask.

Yet when our government says 'we know what's best for you,' when our employer says 'these rules are for your own good,' when capitalism insists 'you're free to choose any job you want as long as it pays enough to pay your rent' – we're told to accept this as normal, even beneficial. The same patterns we'd flee from in a romantic partner, we're expected to embrace in our political and economic relationships.

Consent: The Heart of Healthy Relationships

To understand why consent is necessary for genuine freedom, we need to understand what makes consent real, whether we're talking about a romantic relationship, a friendship, or a political system. Genuine consent requires four interconnected elements, each depending on the others:

Liberty: The Absence of Constraint



At the most basic level, consent cannot exist under physical threat or violence. If someone holds a weapon to your head, your ‘agreement’ isn’t consent, it’s compliance extracted through terror. It is someone constraining you from refusing, from walking away, from exercising any free choice at all.

This seems obvious in personal relationships. We recognise that someone who says ‘yes’ whilst being physically threatened hasn’t truly consented. Their apparent agreement is manufactured through violence.

Yet our economic system operates on precisely this principle. ‘Work or starve’ isn’t meaningfully different from ‘your money or your life’. Both present violence as the alternative to compliance. The violence may be slower, more distributed, and easier to ignore, but hunger kills just as surely as a bullet. When ‘consent’ is extracted through the threat of deprivation, it isn’t consent at all.

Choice: The Absence of Compulsion



Even without overt force, consent requires genuine alternatives.

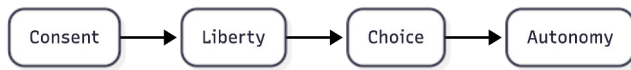
Imagine someone saying: ‘You’re free to leave this relationship anytime you want. Of course, I’ve isolated you from your friends and family, you have no money of your own, and you have nowhere else to go, but you’re completely free to choose.’

We recognise this as manipulation, not freedom. The technical ability to walk away doesn’t constitute real choice when one option has been made deliberately untenable.

Yet this is exactly how capitalism presents ‘freedom’. You’re ‘free’ to quit your exploitative job, but you need money for housing, food, and healthcare. You’re ‘free’ to refuse any particular employer, but you must have an employer to survive. When the alternative to compliance is destitution, calling it ‘choice’ is a cruel joke.

True choice requires multiple viable options, not just the formal possibility of alternatives you cannot actually take.

Autonomy: The Absence of Coercion



Autonomy goes deeper than choice. It's the ability to make decisions for yourself without external control shaping what you want, what you believe, or what you think is possible.

In an abusive relationship, this might look like: 'I haven't forbidden you from seeing your friends. You've just decided they're bad for you now. You've come to realise you prefer staying home with me. You've learned that disagreeing with me causes problems, so you've wisely stopped doing it.'

The abuser hasn't forced compliance, they've shaped the victim's perception of their options, their self-worth, and their understanding of what's 'normal' until the victim polices themselves.

Our economic and political systems operate identically. We're not (usually) forced to accept capitalism, we've simply been taught from birth that it's human nature, that alternatives have never worked, and that even thinking about different possibilities is naive or dangerous. We're not forced to accept hierarchy (others ruling over us) we tell ourselves, we've learned that humans need leaders, that we're incapable of self-organisation, and that questioning authority is irresponsible. All of which is untrue.

This is coercion through manufactured consent: shaping people's desires and beliefs until they 'freely choose' what the system needs them to choose.

Anarchy: The Absence of Control



This brings us to the deepest requirement: the absence of imposed, controlling hierarchy itself (anarchy).

Hierarchy is a form of unequal power. It is unwanted domination over the unconsenting. It's the arbitrary claim of one person's right to

make decisions for another, to control resources another needs, to define the terms under which relationship is possible.

In personal relationships, we call this domestic abuse. The abuser establishes themselves as the authority, they set the rules, control the resources, and define what counts as reasonable. The victim must navigate around the abuser's needs, preferences, and demands. Love becomes conditional on obedience.

In most political and economic systems, we may call this normal. But the pattern is identical: one party claims the right to rule, to distribute resources conditionally, and to punish non-compliance. The other party must accept these terms or face consequences. Participation requires submission to authority.

You cannot have genuine consent within hierarchy because hierarchy itself is the negation of equality that consent requires. When one party has power over another, when a relationship is conditional on obedience, when resources and survival depend on pleasing authority then genuine consent becomes impossible.

The Interconnected Web

These elements don't just coexist, they require each other, forming an interconnected web where each supports and enables the others. Anarchy sits at the centre, enabling each element by removing a specific barrier:

- Liberty through absence of hierarchy
- Autonomy through absence of coercion
- Choice through absence of compulsion
- Consent through absence of force

These elements reinforce each other in a continuous cycle: liberty enables consent, which requires choice, which enables autonomy, which reinforces liberty. Remove any one element, and the entire structure collapses.

This is why partial reforms never deliver full freedom. You cannot have freedom without autonomy, autonomy without choice, choice without consent, or consent without anarchy (freedom from rulers). They're inseparable.

What This Means for Love

Real love – whether romantic, platonic, or communal – requires this complete web of mutually supporting freedoms.

Love cannot flourish under hierarchy because hierarchy makes genuine consent impossible. When one person has power over another, every interaction is coloured by that inequality. Does your partner truly want to spend time with you, or do they fear the consequences of refusing? Do they share your interests, or have they learned to adopt your preferences to keep the peace? Do they love you, or have they simply learned that survival requires pleasing you? You cannot know (and more importantly, they cannot freely choose) when hierarchy structures the relationship.

The same applies to politics, to solidarity, mutual aid, and communal progress. When hierarchy structures our economic and political relationships, we cannot know whether people participate because they genuinely want to contribute to collective wellbeing or because the system punishes non-compliance with destitution and violence.

The Abuser's Playbook: Personal and Political

The parallels between abusive relationships and hierarchical systems aren't coincidental, they follow the same logic because they serve the same function: maintaining power through control.

- Stage 1 - The Honeymoon: 'I'll take care of everything. Trust me. Life will be so much better when you don't have to worry about all these decisions.'
- Stage 2 - Creating Dependency: 'You don't need those friends anymore. I'll handle the finances. Why would you want to work when I can provide for you?'
- Stage 3 - Testing Boundaries: 'I'm just checking in because I care. It's not controlling to want to know where you are. These expectations are for your protection.'

- Stage 4 - Consolidating Control: ‘You’ve become so difficult lately. Remember how good we had it? I’m only strict because you’ve given me reason not to trust you.’
- Stage 5 - Raw Enforcement: ‘Where would you go? Who would take you in? You need me. Without me, you’d have nothing.’
- Now read it again, but imagine it’s capitalism or the state speaking, or any hierarchical institution. It would look something like this:

Stage	Capitalism	The State
<i>Stage 1: The Honeymoon</i>	‘Free markets will lift all boats. Trust the invisible hand. Life will be so much better when you don't have to worry about collective decisions. Just pursue your self-interest and prosperity will follow.’	‘We'll protect you and provide services. Trust your representatives. Life will be so much better when you don't have to worry about security and infrastructure, just vote and let us handle governance.’
<i>Stage 2: Creating Dependency</i>	‘You don't need the commons anymore. We'll handle production efficiently. Why would you want communal ownership when private enterprise delivers everything you need? Just focus on your job.’	‘You don't need community defence or mutual aid networks. We'll handle security and welfare. Why would you want to organise yourselves when we can provide order and support so much more efficiently?’
<i>Stage 3: Testing Boundaries</i>	‘We're just monitoring productivity because we care about the company. It's not controlling to track your work. These workplace rules are for everyone's benefit. The cameras are for your safety.’	‘We're just collecting metadata because we care about security. It's not surveillance to monitor communications. These laws are for your protection. If you've done nothing wrong, you have nothing to hide.’

<i>Stage 4: Consolidating Control</i>	‘Workers have become so entitled lately. Remember how good you had it before unions caused problems? We’re only cutting benefits because some have been abusing them. These austerity measures are necessary to help the economy.’	‘Citizens have become so ungrateful lately. Remember when we provided stability? We’re only increasing enforcement because of the troublemakers. These emergency powers are necessary because of the threats others created through their resistance.’
<i>Stage 5: Naked Enforcement</i>	‘Where would you work? Who would hire you with that attitude? You need this job. Without employment, you’d starve. Without us, the economy would collapse.’	‘Where would you go? What country would take you? You need this state. Without us, you’d have chaos and violence. Try to oppose us and you’ll face the full force of the law.’

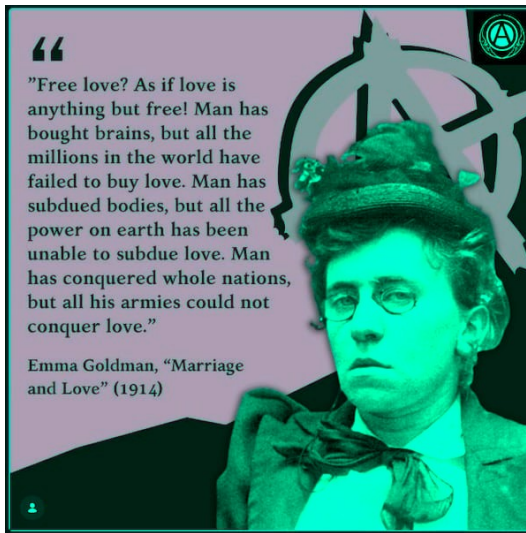
The pattern is identical because the purpose is identical: to establish and maintain unequal power by destroying the conditions necessary for consent.

Common Objections

‘But surely some hierarchy is necessary? Children need parents, students need teachers, societies need organisation.’

- This conflates hierarchy with care, education, and coordination. All things that can exist without unequal power.
- A parent who respects their child’s growing autonomy, who explains their decisions rather than demanding blind obedience, who prepares the child for self-direction rather than permanent dependence. That isn’t hierarchy. This is temporary guardianship that aims at its own dissolution.
- A teacher who facilitates learning rather than enforcing knowledge, who respects students’ questions and encourages critical thinking, who shares expertise without demanding submission. That isn’t hierarchy. This is horizontal knowledge-sharing.

- A community that coordinates through voluntary cooperation, where each person's voice matters equally, where decisions emerge from discussion rather than command. That isn't hierarchy. This is the anarchist organising in action.



The question isn't whether we need relationships, structure, or organisation. The question is whether these things require unequal power, and the answer is no.

Building Consent-Based Relationships

So what does a consent-based world look like? In personal relationships, it means:

- Partners who genuinely respect each other's autonomy
- Decisions made through discussion, not domination
- Resources shared freely, not controlled conditionally
- The freedom to leave without facing destitution or danger
- Love that deepens freedom rather than restricting it

In political relationships, it means:

- Economic / distribution systems where survival isn't conditional on submission
- Communities organised through voluntary cooperation
- Resources held in common and distributed according to need
- The ability to associate or dissociate freely
- Combined Power that flows from mutual aid rather than coercion

The relational and political aren't two separate visions. They're the same vision applied at different scales. Both require the same fundamental shift: from relationships structured by power to relationships structured by consent.

Valentine's Day

When we celebrate love on Valentine's Day or any other day, let's ask ourselves: what kind of love are we celebrating? The love that demands obedience? That requires submission? That punishes autonomy? That insists we accept control 'for our own good'?

Or do we celebrate the love that trusts? That respects? That celebrates autonomy? That flourishes through mutual freedom rather than despite it?

If we wouldn't accept the first kind of love in our personal relationships (and we shouldn't) why do we accept it in our political and economic ones?

Anarchism isn't just a political philosophy. It's the recognition that the same principles making personal relationships healthy apply to all human relationships. It's the insistence that love –whether personal or political – cannot coexist with hierarchy. It's the simple, radical claim that consent matters in every relationship, not just romantic ones.

And it's the promise that another world is possible: one where all our relationships, from the personal to the political, honour rather than violate consent. Where freedom and love aren't opposites but partners. Where we can say 'I love you' and also mean 'I trust you to be free'. That's the world worth building. That's the love worth fighting for.

Anarchy Is For Lovers

They came together-red and black-
In a revolt like no other,
And there is no turning back,
For anarchy is for lovers.

The truth is greater than the lies
Of hollow gods and class divisions,
For loving hearts all rules defy
With a transcendent common vision.

No wars, no boundaries, no states,
No need to subjugate each other,
No rich, no poor, no one to hate-
Just peace and love for one another. ...

They saw the truth, they saw the light
In a revolt like no other,
Standing determined in their fight,
For anarchy is for lovers.

Alexander Shaumyan